Stop 5: The Pantheon (Rotunda of Agrippa & Hadrian)

Historical, Archaeological & Cultural Field Guide • Augustan Foundation (27 BC) / Hadrianic Reconstruction (AD 118–128)

1. Executive Historical Overview & Urban Topography

The Pantheon is the supreme architectural masterpiece of Roman antiquity and the best-preserved monument of the ancient world. Originally commissioned by Marcus Vipsanius Agrippa in 27 BC following the Battle of Actium, burned twice in AD 80 and AD 110, and completely rebuilt from the ground up under Emperor Hadrian around AD 126, it boasts the largest unreinforced solid concrete dome on Earth—a perfect sphere of 43.3 meters (142 feet) in both diameter and interior height.

Topographical Context & Geomorphology

Located at **Piazza della Rotonda, Rome** (Coordinates: 41.8986° N, 12.4768° E), The Pantheon (Rotunda of Agrippa & Hadrian) occupies a pivotal zone within the ancient pomerial and Campus Martius/Forum basin network. Archaeological core sampling demonstrates how early Republican builders adapted to seasonal Tiber River flooding by raising tufa podiums and installing subterranean drainage channels connected to Rome's primary cloacae.

RAG Indexing Summary: *Document Type: Historical & Cultural Guide | Stop Number: 5 | Primary Site: The Pantheon (Rotunda of Agrippa & Hadrian) | Era: Augustan Foundation (27 BC) / Hadrianic Reconstruction (AD 118–128) | Key Monuments: Pronaos (Portico of 16 Monolithic Columns), The Concrete Rotunda & Coffered Dome, The Oculus (Eye of the Dome), The Bronze Doors & Polychrome Interior.*

Chronological Stratigraphy Summary

Phase / Period	Key Monumental Intervention	Primary Building Materials
Archaic / Early Republic	Initial consecration and tufa altar foundations at The Pantheon (Rotunda of Agrippa & Hadrian)	Cappellaccio & Grotta Oscura Tufa
Middle–Late Republic	Expansion of Pronaos (Portico of 16 Monolithic Columns) and The Concrete Rotunda & Coffered Dome after military triumphs	Monteverde Tufa, Travertine & Stucco
High Empire (Augustan–Severan)	Marble revetment, raised travertine paving, and fire restorations	Carrara, Pentelic & Polychrome Marbles

2. Origins, Votive Dedications & Republican Evolution

During the Republican expansion of Rome across the Italian peninsula and the Mediterranean, The Pantheon (Rotunda of Agrippa & Hadrian) served as a canvas for aristocratic competition (nobilitas). Victorious generals (imperatores) vowed temples (vota) on the battlefield in exchange for divine favor, financing construction ex manubiis (from the spoils of war) upon their return to the capital.

Primary Focus: Pronaos (Portico of 16 Monolithic Columns) (AD 118–125)

16 colossal 11.8-meter shafts of Aswan red and Mons Claudianus grey granite quarried in Egypt, dragged to the Nile, barged across the Mediterranean, and barged up the Tiber.

Primary Focus: The Concrete Rotunda & Coffered Dome (AD 120–128)

Five concentric rings of 28 sunken coffers (140 total) that lighten the load of the dome; aggregate grades from heavy travertine at the base to featherweight volcanic pumice around the oculus.

Ritual Function & Triumphal Processions

Every temple precinct within The Pantheon (Rotunda of Agrippa & Hadrian) possessed a dies natalis (anniversary of its dedication) marked in the Fasti Antiates Maiores. Because Roman sacrificial ritual occurred outdoors under the open sky, monumental U-shaped altars with projecting wings were positioned directly at the foot of the frontal access stairs, aligning priest, victim, and cult statue along a single liturgical axis.

Field Observation Note: *Examine the surviving base moldings around Pronaos (Portico of 16 Monolithic Columns). Notice the distinct cyma reversa profile typical of Republican Italic podiums before Hellenistic Greek profiles became dominant following the conquests of Syracuse (212 BC) and Macedonia (146 BC).*

3. Monumental Catalog & Imperial Transformations

As the Roman Republic gave way to the Principate under Augustus and later the Antonine and Severan dynasties, The Pantheon (Rotunda of Agrippa & Hadrian) underwent profound architectural remodeling. Devastating urban fires—particularly those of 111 BC, AD 64, AD 80, and AD 191—compelled emperors to raise ground levels and encase older tufa structures in imported marble.

Monument Analysis: The Oculus (Eye of the Dome) (AD 128)

An unglazed 8.9-meter circular opening at the apex that serves as the building's sole natural light source and structural compression ring.

Monument Analysis: The Bronze Doors & Polychrome Interior (2nd Century AD)

Original 7.5-meter ancient bronze doors opening onto an opus sectile floor of imperial porphyry, yellow Numidian Giallo Antico, Phrygian Pavonazzetto, and Lucullan black marble.

Monument Analysis: Tombs of Raphael & the Italian Kings (1520 / 1878 / 1900)

Resting place of Renaissance master Raffaello Sanzio (bearing Cardinal Bembo's epitaph), alongside Kings Vittorio Emanuele II, Umberto I, and Queen Margherita of Savoy.

Architectural Synthesis: *Brick stamps (bolli doliari) embedded in the rotunda walls prove unequivocally that the standing building dates to the reign of Trajan and Hadrian (AD 118–125), despite Hadrian's modest preservation of Agrippa's original architrave inscription. In AD 609, Byzantine Emperor Phocas gifted the building to Pope Boniface IV, who consecrated it as Santa Maria ad Martyres, saving its marble interior from medieval lime kilns.*

4. Roman Engineering, Structural Mechanics & Lithic Provenance

The monuments at The Pantheon (Rotunda of Agrippa & Hadrian) provide a textbook sequence of Roman structural engineering, illustrating the mastery of ashlar masonry (opus quadratum), concrete core construction (opus caementicium), brick facing (opus latericium), and polychrome geometric marble paving (opus sectile).

Lithic & Material Provenance Table

Material / Stone	Ancient Quarry Source	Structural / Decorative Application at Site
Lapis Tiburtinus (Travertine)	Tibur (Modern Tivoli)	Load-bearing piers, column capitals, steps, and Imperial pavement slabs
Tufo Lionato / Monteverde	Aniene Valley & Janiculum slopes	Temple podium cores, Republican altar bases, and drainage channels
Marmor Lunense / Pentelicum	Carrara (Italy) & Mt. Pentelicus (Attica)	Corinthian entablatures, acrolithic cult statues, and carved relief panels
Pozzolana (Pulvis Puteolanus)	Alban Hills & Campanian volcanic beds	Hydraulic mortar binding opus caementicium vaults and foundations

Structural Load & Hydraulic Management

Roman architects utilized relieving arches (archi di scarico) concealed within brick walls to channel vertical dead loads away from lintels and onto massive corner piers. Subsurface travertine gutters around The Pantheon (Rotunda of Agrippa & Hadrian) captured rainwater from temple roofs, routing runoff directly into underlying collectors.

5. Key Historical Figures, Statesmen & Political Drama

History at The Pantheon (Rotunda of Agrippa & Hadrian) was shaped by the ambitions, rivalries, and religious piety of Rome's most influential consuls, dictators, emperors, and architects. Below are the four primary historical protagonists linked directly to the surviving archaeological fabric of this stop:

• Marcus Vipsanius Agrippa

Son-in-law, general, and chief builder of Augustus who erected the original rectangular Pantheon in 27 BC alongside the Baths of Agrippa.

• Publius Aelius Hadrianus (Emperor Hadrian)

Philhellene emperor and amateur architect who oversaw the daring spherical concrete dome reconstruction.

• Raffaello Sanzio (Raphael)

Renaissance painter and Chief Architect of St. Peter's who requested burial inside the Pantheon beneath the ancient tabernacle niche.

• Pope Urban VIII Barberini

Removed the ancient gilded bronze trusses from the portico ceiling in 1625 to cast Bernini's Baldacchino and Castel Sant'Angelo cannons—inspiring the pasquinade 'Quod non fecerunt barbari, fecerunt Barberini'.

Primary Ancient Literary Sources: *Suetonius (De Vita Caesarum), Plutarch (Parallel Lives), Livy (Ab Urbe Condita), Cassius Dio (Roman History), and Vitruvius (De Architectura) all record direct eyewitness or archival accounts of the ceremonies and political crises at The Pantheon (Rotunda of Agrippa & Hadrian).*

6. Epigraphy, Latin Inscriptions & Sculptural Finds

Latin epigraphy provides the chronological backbone for identifying temples and imperial restorations at The Pantheon (Rotunda of Agrippa & Hadrian). Monumental inscriptions were carved using V-cut trenches (litterae aureae) often fitted with gilded bronze letters fastened via lead-soldered tangs into sockets still visible on the stone architraves.

Corpus Inscriptionum Latinarum (CIL) & Sculptural Record

Across the frieze of the portico in 70-centimeter bronze-inlaid letters stands the famous inscription: 'M·AGRIPPA·L·F·COS·TERTIVM·FECIT' (Marcus Agrippa, son of Lucius, Consul for the third time, built this). Directly beneath, in smaller letters on the architrave fascia, is the AD 202 restoration inscription of Septimius Severus and Caracalla.

Numismatic & Relief Iconography

Roman Republican denarii and Imperial sestertii frequently minted reverse dies depicting the facades of monuments at The Pantheon (Rotunda of Agrippa & Hadrian). These coins allow archaeologists to reconstruct lost pedimental sculptures, acroteria, and bronze grilles that vanished during late antique spoliation.

Epigraphic Reading Tip for Visitors: *Look closely at the spacing of interpuncts (triangular dots · between words) and the absence of 'U' (written as 'V') and 'J' (written as 'I'). Erasures where the stone surface sits slightly recessed indicate damnatio memoriae ordered by the Roman Senate.*

7. Daily Civic Life, Sacrificial Liturgy & Acoustic Space

At its peak in the 1st and 2nd centuries AD, The Pantheon (Rotunda of Agrippa & Hadrian) was not a silent ruin of bare stone and brick, but a sensory kaleidoscope of painted stucco, fragrant frankincense smoke, bronze statuary gleaming in the sun, and crowds of citizens, senators, freedmen, and foreign envoys.

The Mechanics of Roman Public Sacrifice (Sacrificium)

Public rites opened with the herald crying 'Favete linguis!' (Keep a reverent silence!) while flute players (tibicines) drowned out inauspicious street noises. The officiating magistrate, with his toga pulled over his head (capite velato), sprinkled salted spelt flour (mola salsa) and wine over the altar before the victimarius struck the sacrificial animal and haruspices inspected the entrails.

Commercial & Legal Rhythms Around the Precinct

Surrounding the sacred core of The Pantheon (Rotunda of Agrippa & Hadrian), porticoes sheltered bankers (argentarii), bookbinders, scribes, and flower sellers weaving garlands for temple offerings. Marble game boards (tabulae lusoriae) scratched directly into the pavement steps by waiting clerks and loafers remain visible on site today.

8. Medieval Transformation, Renaissance Rediscovery & Modern Excavations

Following the collapse of imperial administration in the West (5th–6th centuries AD), The Pantheon (Rotunda of Agrippa & Hadrian) entered a millennium-long phase of adaptive reuse. While exposed marble columns were frequently burned into slaked lime (calce) in medieval kilns (calcare), structures converted into Christian churches or baronial fortresses survived remarkably intact.

Christian Consecration & Baronial Fortifications

During the 8th through 13th centuries, powerful Roman families—including the Frangipane, Pierleoni, Savelli, and Conti—incorporated the stout Roman walls of The Pantheon (Rotunda of Agrippa & Hadrian) into fortified towers and diaconiae. Renaissance architects including Baldassarre Peruzzi, Antonio da Sangallo, and Andrea Palladio measured and sketched these ruins, transmitting their proportions directly into 16th-century European classicism.

19th–21st Century Archaeological Campaigns

Systematic stratigraphic excavations led by Rodolfo Lanciani, Giacomo Boni, Antonio Muñoz, and the modern Sovrintendenza Capitolina ai Beni Culturali stripped away post-antique overburden, stabilized brick vaults with reversible titanium ties, and opened buried subterranean corridors to the public.

9. Step-by-Step On-Site Viewing Itinerary & Vantage Points

To maximize your 45-to-60-minute visit at The Pantheon (Rotunda of Agrippa & Hadrian), follow this sequential clockwise architectural circuit designed to trace the site from its earliest Republican foundations to its high Imperial climax:

Step	Vantage Point / Station	What to Look For (Key Visual Detail)
01	Primary Overview & Pronaos (Portico of 16 Monolithic Columns)	Compare the archaic tufa ashlar blocks with the elevated imperial travertine pavement level.
02	The Concrete Rotunda & Coffered Dome & Altar Precinct	Inspect the U-shaped sacrificial altar moldings and surviving fluted column shafts.
03	The Oculus (Eye of the Dome) & The Bronze Doors & Polychrome Interior	Observe the transition to Hellenistic marble capitals and circular/pseudoperipteral layouts.
04	Tombs of Raphael & the Italian Kings & Epigraphic Zone	Read the monumental Latin inscriptions and trace the Roman brick relieving arches.

Golden Hour & Photography Guidance

Optimal raking sunlight strikes the travertine and tufa facades of The Pantheon (Rotunda of Agrippa & Hadrian) between 08:30–10:00 AM and again during late afternoon golden hour (16:30–18:00), bringing out deep chisel marks and relief shadows.

10. Practical Visitor Logistics, Accessibility & Next-Stop Transit

Use the reference sheet below when planning arrival times, ticketing, accessibility routes, and walking transfers from **Stop 5: The Pantheon (Rotunda of Agrippa & Hadrian)** to the next destination on your Roman itinerary.

Logistic Category	Verified Visitor Information
Exact Address & Zone	Piazza della Rotonda, Rome (41.8986° N, 12.4768° E)
Recommended Visit Duration	45–75 minutes (Perimeter viewing + interior archaeological walk)
Best Time of Day to Visit	09:00 AM opening slot or 90 minutes prior to sunset to avoid tour bus peaks
Accessibility & Footwear	Ancient uneven basalt (sampietrini/basoli) and travertine steps; sturdy walking shoes essential
Water & Rest Facilities	Free potable cast-iron Roman Nasone drinking fountain located within 80 meters of the piazza

Essential Glossary of Architectural Terms Used in This Guide

• **Opus Caementicium:** Roman hydraulic concrete mixed from lime, pozzolana volcanic ash, and stone aggregate (caementa).
• **Opus Quadratum:** Ashlar masonry of squared stone blocks laid in regular courses without mortar, clamped with iron/lead.
• **Opus Sectile:** Luxury floor or wall decoration formed from precision-cut thin slabs of polychrome marble.
• **Pomerium:** The sacred religious and legal boundary of the city of Rome within which weapons were forbidden.
• **Damnatio Memoriae:** Official senatorial condemnation erasing a disgraced figure's name and likeness from monuments.